

**KEEPING COUNT: A
Pratham camp in Kasar
in Haryana**

of positive construction amidst madness," says Lambay, who is also the vice-principal of Nirmala Niketan College of Social Work.

Backed by UNICEF, funds from ICICI Bank and the support of the then Mumbai municipal commissioner, Sharad Kale, Pratham began its journey, working out of Chavan's living room. The structure was simple—a triangular partnership between citizens, corporations and the government.

But starting out, they were not without

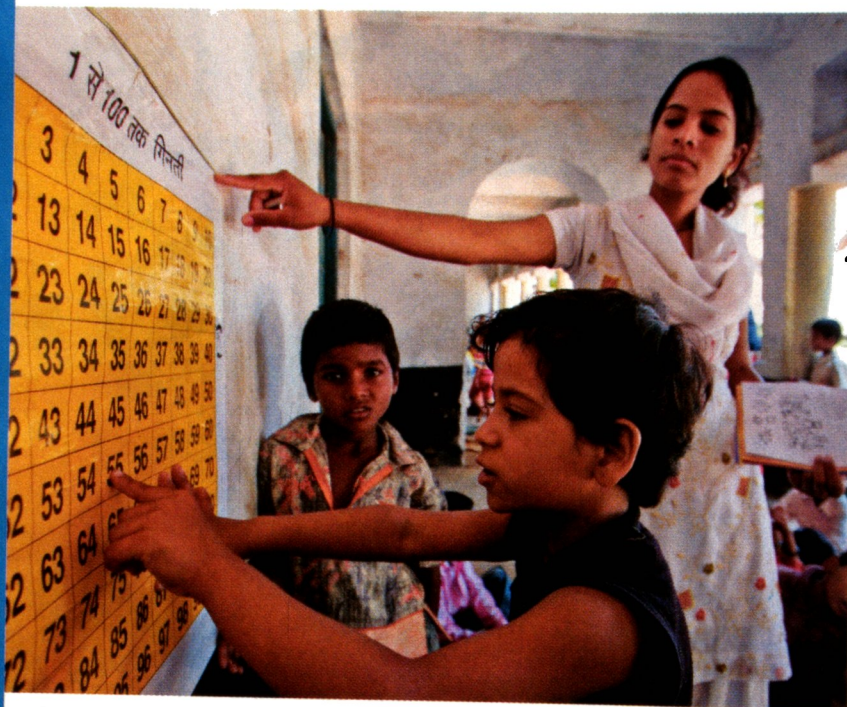
University, and also involved in the National Literacy Mission. The sheer simplicity of the structure allowed Pratham to grow beyond the confines of Mumbai, working with different trusts like AID India and Akshara Foundation and support from a long list of donors which includes S.P. Godrej, Citibank and HPCL.

Balwadis can be set up anywhere—a balcony in a chawl, by a temple, under a tree; teachers are from the local community, working as volunteers or on basic salaries, with books, test material and training provided by Pratham. It is a low-cost, easy-to-replicate model and it's been their secret to success. "We went from 100 balwadis in 1994 to 3,200 three years later. That is one in every slum in Mumbai," says Rukmini Banerji, director, research and programming with Pratham. Since then, special programmes like Balsakhi for children lagging behind in school, outreach classes for child labourers and bridge courses for drop-outs between the ages of six and 10 have been introduced. Pratham has also rescued child labourers and brought the number down to 7,000 from 31,000 in Mumbai. "The response from the community was something we never had to worry about. Parents wanted their children to be educated," says Lambay, 57, adding that even with her own family and two sons, Nihal and Samir, she was planning policy and ironing out organisational hitches "24x7 in my mind".

Pratham has gone one step further with its Read India campaign. The aim is to reach 60 million children by March 2009, teaching them to read in their local languages and do basic arithmetic. Meenal Kumari, a 19-year-old volunteer in Haryana's Kasar village, is part of this campaign. Kumari has cleared her Class XII examination and wants to go to college but the family's finances have made her give up the idea.

But the sheer scale of the campaign calls for deep pockets, the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation and Hewlett Foundation in the US being two of the largest donors. The campaign is also supported by corporations like Dell Foundation, Merrill Lynch and New York Life in the US and Europe.

Chavan's "socio-political mission" is far from complete, his dream of seeing every child in school and learning well, yet to come true. But it's a dream that has allowed children like Nikita to curl up with a brightly illustrated, laminated story card and be drawn into another world.



REUBEN SINGH

Nothing is impossible if you work for it and challenge yourself to think innovatively for viable alternatives.

FARIDA LAMBAY, Co-founder, Pratham

sceptics. "We were accused of talking only numbers, not quality. But in a city where in 1993, two lakh children were not in school, scale was important. It's not enough to make a model and leave it to the government to scale up. You have to go beyond that to make a difference," says Chavan, 54, then a chemistry professor at the Bombay